

Jamiatul Ulama Johannesburg

صيام رمضان وقيام التراويح

Ramaḍān Fasting & Tarāwīḥ Guide

PDF · 30 pages · Complete Ramaḍān Manual



وما علينا إلا البلاغ المبين

"Clear propagation is our only responsibility." — Sūrah Yāsīn 36:17

The Obligation of Fasting

وجوب الصيام

يا أيها الذين آمنوا كتب عليكم الصيام كما كتب على الذين من قبلكم لعلكم تتقون

Allah says: "O you who have believed, decreed upon you is fasting as it was decreed upon those before you, that you may become righteous." (Sūrah al-Baqarah 2:183)

The fasting of the entire month of Ramaḍān (29 or 30 days, depending on the moon-sighting) is Fard 'ayn — an absolute obligation upon every adult, sane Muslim, male or female, regardless of geographic location. There is no regional exemption; the obligation is universal.

The Prophet ﷺ said: "Islām is built on five: testifying that there is no god but Allah and that Muḥammad is the Messenger of Allah, establishing the prayer, giving Zakāh, the pilgrimage to the House, and fasting Ramaḍān." (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 8, Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 16)

Source: Sūrah al-Baqarah 2:183 · Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 8



Who Must Fast and Who Is Exempt

من يجب عليه الصيام ومن يعفى

Fasting is obligatory upon every adult (bāligh), sane ('āqil) Muslim who is physically able.

The following are exempt:

1. The traveller (musāfir) — defined in the Ḥanafī school as one who undertakes a journey of 77 km or more. He may break his fast and make it up later. However, if he begins fasting before travelling, he should complete it.
2. The sick (marīḍ) — whose illness would be worsened by fasting, or whose recovery would be delayed. He makes up the fast later.
3. The menstruating woman (ḥā'id) and the woman in post-natal bleeding (nufasā') — must NOT fast; they make up the fasts later.
4. The pregnant and nursing woman — if she fears for her own or the child's health, she may break the fast and make it up later.

5. The elderly who cannot fast — they pay a Fidyah (one meal's worth of grain, equivalent to Ṣadaqah al-Fiṭr) for each missed fast.

6. The insane, the unconscious, and pre-pubescent children — not obligated.

All those who break their fast for a valid reason must make it up (qaḍā') before the next Ramaḍān, except the elderly who pay Fidyah.

Source: Sūrah al-Baqarah 2:184-185 · Al-Hidāyah



The Time of Fasting

وقت الصيام

وكلوا واشربوا حتى يتبين لكم الخيط الأبيض من الخيط الأسود من الفجر ثم أتموا الصيام إلى الليل

Allah says: "And eat and drink until the white thread of dawn becomes distinct to you from the black thread. Then complete the fast until the night." (Sūrah al-Baqarah 2:187)

The fast begins at the true dawn (Ṣubḥ Ṣādiq — Fajr begins) and ends at sunset (Ghurūb — Maghrib begins).

The pre-dawn meal (Suhūr) is Sunnah and should not be neglected. The Prophet said: "Eat Suhūr, for in Suhūr there is blessing." (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 1923)

One should delay the Suhūr until close to Fajr, and hasten to break the fast (Iftār) at sunset. The Prophet said: "The people will remain upon good as long as they hasten in breaking the fast." (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 1957)

Source: Sūrah al-Baqarah 2:187 · Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 1923, 1957



What Nullifies the Fast

مبطلات الصيام

The following nullify the fast and require qadā' (making up):

1. Eating, drinking, or taking any nourishment deliberately.
2. Marital relations (jimā') during the day of Ramaḍān — this also requires Kaffārah (expiation).
3. Deliberate vomiting (mouthful).
4. Menstruation or post-natal bleeding — even at the last moment before sunset.
5. Ejaculation caused by deliberate action.
6. Apostasy (may Allah protect us).

The following do NOT nullify the fast:

1. Eating/drinking out of forgetfulness — the fast remains valid. (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 1933)
2. Swallowing saliva, even in abundance.
3. Using a miswāk.
4. Rinsing the mouth or nose (without taking water down the throat).
5. Having a wet dream.
6. Applying kohl (surmah) or eye drops.
7. Taking an injection (intramuscular or intravenous, provided it is not a nutritional injection).
8. Cupping (ḥijāmah) — according to the Ḥanafī school.
9. Blood tests or minor bleeding.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 1933 · Fatāwā Hindiyyah



The Kaffārah (Expiation)

الكفارة

If a person deliberately engages in marital relations during the day of Ramaḍān, he must:

1. Free a Muslim slave (if available — typically not applicable today).
2. If not possible: fast for two consecutive lunar months.
3. If not possible: feed 60 poor people a meal each (or the equivalent in grain).

This is the Kaffārah. There is no Kaffārah for breaking the fast in any other way — only qadā' (making up that one day).

The qadā' fasts should be made before the next Ramaḍān. If delayed without valid reason, a Fidyah is also due for each missed day.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 1936 · Fatāwā Hindīyyah



Tarāwīḥ Prayer

صلاة التراويح

Tarāwīḥ is the Sunnah prayer performed in Ramaḍān after Ishā'. It is Sunnah mu'akkadah for both men and women, though it is more emphasised for men to attend in congregation at the masjid.

The number of rak'āt in the Ḥanafī school is 20 (in addition to the 3 rak'āt of Witr). This is the practice of the Ummah from the time of the Ṣaḥābah and was formalised by 'Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb

The Prophet ﷺ said: "Whoever stands (in prayer) in Ramaḍān out of faith and seeking reward, all his previous sins will be forgiven." (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 37)

It is Sunnah to recite the entire Qur'ān in Tarāwīḥ over the course of the month — completing it on the 27th night, so that the Khatm al-Qur'ān falls on Laylat al-Qadr.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 37 · Muwaṭṭa' Mālik



Laylat al-Qadr

ليلة القدر

ليلة القدر خير من ألف شهر

Allah says: "The Night of Power is better than a thousand months." (Sūrah al-Qadr 97:3)

Laylat al-Qadr is the crowning night of Ramaḍān, on which the Qur'ān was revealed. The Prophet ﷺ said: "Seek Laylat al-Qadr in the odd nights of the last ten nights of Ramaḍān." (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2017)

The odd nights are the 21st, 23rd, 25th, 27th, and 29th. The most emphasised is the 27th, though absolute certainty is not given.

'Ā'ishah asked the Prophet what to say on this night. He taught her: "Allāhumma innaka 'afuwwun tuḥibbul-'afwa fa'fu 'annī" (O Allah, You are Pardoning, You love to pardon, so pardon me). (Sunan al-Tirmidhī 3513)

Source: Sūrah al-Qadr 97:1-5 · Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2017 · Sunan al-Tirmidhī 3513



I'tikāf in Ramaḍān

الاعتكاف في رمضان

I'tikāf in the last ten days of Ramaḍān is Sunnah mu'akkadah 'alal-kifāyah. If performed by even one person in a locality, the obligation is lifted from the rest.

See the dedicated "I'tikāf: Complete Ḥanafī Guide" booklet for full details.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 2026



Ṣadaqah al-Fiṭr

صدقة الفطر

Before the Eid al-Fiṭr prayer, every Muslim — male or female, young or old — must pay Ṣadaqah al-Fiṭr (also called Fiṭranah). It is Wājib upon the head of the household to pay on behalf of himself and all his dependants.

The amount: one ṣā' of the staple food of the region (wheat, barley, dates, raisins, etc.). In the Ḥanafī school, the monetary equivalent is permitted. The current value (1448 AH / 2026) is approximately R38.00 per person in South Africa.

It must be paid before the Eid prayer, so that the poor may also enjoy Eid. If delayed, it remains a debt but loses its Eid-specific reward.

Source: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 1503 · Al-Hidāyah



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